for clemency for Afzal] is disgusting. How can we pardon a terrorist mastermind? My blood was boiling when I saw the news and when they [BJP] asked me to participate in the morcha, I immediately agreed.' He indicated that his willingness to join the campaign against any deferral or clemency in the matter of Afzal Guru was evidence of his commitment to the BJP: 'I have been brought up in the BJP and the party is in my blood. I will definitely participate in such events in future, especially if the issue is close to my heart.' Clearly, patriotism, commitment to the BJP, 'anti-terrorist' activism and an implacable hatred for Afzal Guru run furiously alongside traces of other and equally powerful narcotic substances in Rahul Mahajan's bloodstream.

The only Indian politician of any stature who has publicly expressed a principled opposition to the death penalty, and to capital punishment as such, is the DMK patriarch K. Karunanidhi. The Indian political class's romance with the death penalty is not anything new, and we must remember that even Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi could see nothing wrong in Bhagat Singh being hanged. Capital punishment and the core values of Indian nationalism seem to have a close relationship. Perhaps they are both predicated on the idea that the nation-state and the rule of law demands sacrificial victims from time to time to re-invigorate the tired vitality of its foundations. The Indian State hanged Kehar Singh when it could not find anyone else to hang in order to restore it's vitality in the Indira Gandhi assassination case, and this time, Mohammad Afzal Guru must serve that necessary function. Perhaps Giorgio Agamben—whose rediscovery of the concept of the pariah-turned-sacrificial victim of the foundational violence of the State through the term *Homo Sacer* — has found such contemporary resonance in the light of Abu Ghraib and Guantanamo Bay—needs to turn his attention to the precincts of the maximum security ward in Tihar Jail. Mohammad Afzal Guru is as likely a candidate today as any for the status of Homo Sacer.

Recently, Vir Sanghvi, another eminent media mandarin, wrestled with his conscience about whether or not Afzal should hang in a large op-ed piece in the *Hindustan Times* (15 October 2006),[2] next to a smaller piece from Karan Thapar[3] that hesitantly takes a different view. And like all good Indian liberals who won debating prizes in high school, Sanghvi too does this by dispassionately examining the pros (good strong signal to 'terrorists') and cons (this damn inconvenience of the fact that he did not really have a legal defence) of execution before saying something like 'Um, yes, maybe, there